INC-2026-02-03: Token-bucket rate limiting shared by all edge services degradation

Northwind Payments · SEV1 · service rate-limiter · author j.barros

Started 2026-02-03T13:00:00Z · detected 2026-02-03T13:05:00Z · resolved 2026-02-03T13:22:00Z

Customer impact

All edge services accepted unthrottled traffic for 90 seconds. payment-gateway latency rose to 4.1s at p99 under the surge.

Root cause

A Redis cluster failover promoted a replica that was 40 seconds behind, resetting token buckets and briefly allowing unlimited request rates.

Causing change

This incident was caused by release rl-1.9.2, deployed to rate-limiter. The release is recorded in the change log.

Affected services

rate-limiter, payment-gateway. Downstream services were affected through their dependency on rate-limiter.

Timeline (UTC)

13:00 — Release rl-1.9.2 completed rollout earlier in the day.

13:00 — First symptoms observed on rate-limiter.

13:05 — Alert pages the on-call engineer for rate-limiter.

13:13 — Cause identified and mitigation begins.

13:22 — Service returns to baseline; incident resolved.

Action items

• Review the third-party contract for change notification.

• Require a load test for configuration changes of this class.

• Add a pre-deploy validation check for rate-limiter.